seen among the Congress party karyakartas. For years together, they had been asking for opportunities to converse with the national leadership. The Yatra allowed them space to rub shoulders with the upper echelons of the Congress party. Their morale was elevated as never before. All of this generated some political heft as well. The moral, aesthetic, social and political capital gathered and brought together by the Yatra was an indication of the seismic shift that the Indian political arena is going through.

Rahul Gandhi was frank and articulate throughout the Yatra. He made it clear again and again that the Yatra had nothing to do with the coming state elections. He repeatedly described it as a ‘tapasya’—a pilgrimage for introspection and self-searching. He also described it as a journey to know India intimately. His companions in the Yatra, too, did not talk politics, but rather of taking politics to a higher plane. They have collectively shaped and are shaping a new political idiom. It is very far from the language of politics that is marooned in communalism, divisive rhetoric and innuendoes that constantly go back to the Partition of India and the birth of Pakistan. The discourse of the yatris was filled with metaphors of love, concern, compassion, innocence and self-search.

The Yatra’s Culmination: The Yatra for the Dreams Yet Not Realized

The year 1942 was a turbulent one. In India, the Muslim League had already demanded a separate nation for Muslims, and the air was charged with communalism. The war in Europe had spread to other continents, and the British wanted India to support their war effort. The Cripps Mission was sent to India in March 1942. Its demand that India participate in the war caused tremendous resentment in the country, especially because there was no prior consultation with Indian leaders. Outside India, the Indian National Army (INA) was created under Rash Behari Bose and its command handed over to Subhas Chandra Bose later that year. Hitler’s forces were deep